

KILLZONE 3

We get to spend some time with Guerrilla's latest Sci-Fi shooter, and walk away (somewhat) impressed.



Badri "Badjag" Narayan
readersletters@thinkdigit.com

Now that the madness of the peak gaming season with its rush of pre-Christmas releases is behind us, the industry is in the midst of a small breather before the onslaught begins anew in the weeks to come. On the frontlines of this fresh spring wave of AAA titles is Sony's mascot in the shooter segment Killzone 3 (K3) competing with Epic's Bulletstorm, both scheduled to release practically on the same day.

Being a PlayStation exclusive, the Killzone series has pretty much been Sony's answer to Microsoft's Halo and Nintendo's—oh wait, the Wii only has Mario, tennis and fishing games. Still, regardless of what PS fanboys might think, Killzone has generally been regarded as the poor man's Halo, mostly due to the giant marketing blitz that precedes each Halo iteration.

Into the zone

In all honesty, I've sampled very little of the Killzone series,

having played only the demo level of the very first game. What I liked about it was its polish and the added hook of getting to play the same level through three different perspectives: the wham-bam heavy gunner, standard heroic soldier, and sneaky sniper. This was followed by Killzone 2, positioned by Sony as the game that would launch its (then) brand-new PS3. Despite being caught out in the initial scam of passing off a pre-rendered cinematic as actual real-time gameplay during its E3 presentation, Guerrilla recovered from the embarrassment and multiple delays to bring out a title that was praised by many. Hence, when the opportunity arose to play a special preview of the upcoming sequel, I accepted right away to see what the hype was all about, and headed over to Milestone Interactive's HQ to run the preview on its debug console.

One of the special features of K3 is its support of the newly-launched PS Move controller, and I was excited to see how it would unshackle gamers from the limitations of the DUAL SHOCK pad. In a

major disappointment though, no Move controllers were available with Milestone at the time, and so I was unable to test what was otherwise one of the USPs of the game. Another major feature that remained untested was K3's co-op mode, since it would have been too awkward to go around the office asking if someone wanted to play with me.

This being a preview, the menu had the barest functionality, with single-player, co-op, and options being the only choices available—sadly, no online play in this build. Going to the Options screen to set up the controls revealed the first glaring flaw in the game: a lack of alternate control configurations. The default (and only) config had assigned the fire button to <R1>, whereas any gamer worth his D-pad knows that it should ideally be <R2>—hey, it's called a trigger button for a reason, right?! The only way to rectify this was to enable the swapping of the <R1> and <R2> buttons

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Publisher: Sony Computer Entertainment
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through the game's Advanced Settings menu; hardly something that could be called intuitive. Hopefully the final release will fix this oversight.

Cliché central

K3 continues the intrepid adventures of Narville, Sev, and Rico, leaders of Alpha Squad, a part of the Legion special forces unit. Continuing from where K2 ended, the team finds itself isolated on the Helghan home planet, cut off from the rest of its force. The crisis deepens as our heroes discover that a massive Helghast counterattack on their home planet of Vekta is imminent, and they are all that stand in the way of total Helghast domination. Meanwhile, the plot gets murkier due to a power struggle within the Helghast high command.

It didn't take more than a minute into the level intro